

Subtextual Intelligence: Enhancing Emotional Intelligence for Text-based Chatbots using Stanislavski's acting theory

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Abstract

An AI possesses neither a body, a soul, nor a heart. It cannot feel or empathize; it can only reproduce and simulate a state of what it is like to be alive. This paper argues that performance-based methods, specifically those derived from Stanislavski's acting theory, can help assess and enhance the emotional believability of AI-generated responses. Central to this exploration is the concept of subtext. While current AI systems can reproduce surface-level expressions of emotion, they cannot fully "embody a role" [Mat13, BB83] or convincingly convey the unspoken intentions and motivations that gives human communication its depth [Ho22].

To investigate this, an experiment was conducted in which four AI systems generated responses to the same scenario under two prompt conditions: (1) role and question only, and (2) role and question with Stanislavski methodology instructions. A perception survey (n = 31) asked participants to judge which responses felt more believable and natural. Results showed a consistent tendency to prefer the Stanislavski-based responses (65.3% overall), suggesting that theatrical methods may enhance the perceived emotional depth of AI outputs.

1. Introduction

The Turing Test, first introduced by Alan Turing in 1950, was designed to evaluate whether a machine can imitate human conversation well enough to be mistaken for a real person. It has since become a key method in the study of artificial intelligence (AI) [Liv06]. However, a significant limitation of this traditional approach is its absence of a measurable criteria for emotional value [Ho22]. While AI systems have made progress in emotion recognition and response mechanisms [NNI*24], the current form of emotional AI is often debated by scholar to be described as *weak* and *narrow*, limited by the lack of capacity to truly understand or experience its information processing. This means that while a chatbot might generate grammatically suitable and contextually relevant responses, it often fails to convey the subtle, underlying emotional nuances that are crucial for human-like communication. Responses often appear correct on the surface but may lack emotional *depth* [FK25], such as clear motivation, tone, or subtext.

Performance-based methods, particularly those inspired by Stanislavski's acting theory, can help extend the emotional intelligence (EI) of text-based chatbots in what I term *subtextual intelligence*. Current research on Affective Computing often assumes a "natural-kind view of emotions," where affect which is understood as a basic mood state (e.g., pleasant to unpleasant and calm to excited) is treated as measurable information through body movements and facial expressions, and reduced to basic categories such as sadness or happiness. Although this approach supports recogni-

tion and labeling, it struggles to capture the complexity of emotions as socially and culturally situated experiences [ALF*25]. By contrast, Stanislavski's method emphasizes the interpretation of emotion within context, framing expression as dynamic narratives of human experience [BB83]. This perspective better aligns with the need for a new framework that enhances the believability of responses, rather than their ability to mimic surface-level emotions.

The guiding question for this paper is: *In what ways can principles from Stanislavski's acting theory be integrated into a framework to enhance emotional believability in text-based chatbot interactions?*

This paper focuses on emotional intelligence, its definition within AI, its practical applications, and its potential to enhance text-based chatbot interactions. By drawing on Stanislavski's acting system, it seeks to explore how believable emotions can be simulated in a more natural manner.

1.1. Related Work

The definitions provided for AI's emotional intelligence primarily describe capabilities related to recognition, prediction, and response generation based on data patterns. This stands in contrast to the human definition of EI, which inherently includes subjective experience and authentic understanding. The technical feasibility of statistical pattern recognition and machine learning enables the development of affective computing systems capable of simulating emotional intelligence, but this does not inherently lead to

the first-hand way someone experiences an emotion and a much layered form of understanding them [PLA*25]. Within the AI research community, there is considerable debate. While some scholars maintain that AI is limited to complex data processing, others argue that its capacities may extend towards forms of comprehension or even consciousness [BGMS21].

1.2. Approach & Scope

This paper emphasizes the framework development for assessing *subtextual intelligence* in chatbots. While a full-scale empirical test is beyond the scope of this short paper, examples are provided to demonstrate the practical application of the proposed framework. These examples will serve as the first proof-of-concept of the theory of *subtextual intelligence*, highlighting how the adapted methodology can be used to enhance chatbots for text-based scenarios in need of emotional depth.

2. Emotional Believability as a Missing Dimension

Meng explains that an "actor's belief", a key idea in Stanislavski's system, is the ability to treat fictional circumstances as real. This allows performances to appear authentic, fostering empathy and emotional connection. Emotional believability, therefore, depends on the audience perceiving the actor's portrayal as genuine and consistent with the character's situation, even when the actor is not truly feeling the emotion [Men24]. The limitations of emotional AI are a key topic in current research, with several papers highlighting the gap between basic emotion detection and true emotional understanding. While AI systems can perform basic "sentiment analysis" to spot emotional cues in text, Finet et al.'s paper argues that they often fail to grasp nuanced or complex emotional states. This means an AI might correctly identify "sadness," but miss the subtle mix of sadness and hope that a human would easily pick up on [FK25]. Narimisaie et al. echo this idea, pointing out that AI struggles with the messy, context-driven nature of emotional expressions in humans. In other words, simply detecting an emotion isn't enough; the AI needs to understand why that emotion is being expressed and how the environment or situation influences it [NNI*24].

3. Defining Emotional Intelligence in AI and Affective Computing

In human contexts, emotional intelligence is defined as the capacity to comprehend, identify, and regulate emotions within oneself and others. It encompasses crucial components such as self-awareness, self-regulation, social awareness, and relationship management [Dwi25].

Affective computing systems are designed to automatically identify and respond to human emotions by analyzing various cues, including facial expressions, voice tone, and physiological signals. Applications span various areas, including enhancing emotional interaction in education (e.g., intelligent teaching systems, educational games) and enabling scientific identification and judgement of patient emotions in healthcare (e.g., diagnosis of psychiatric disorder, stress relief, monitoring of mental state) [PLL*24].

The core definitions stated for AI emotional intelligence are

on computational function, describing capabilities like emotional recognition (labeling, categorizing emotions) and predictive response generation derived from massive datasets. This stands in contrast to the human definition of EI, which inherently includes experiencing an emotion by feeling it. The technical feasibility of statistical pattern recognition and machine learning enables the development of affective computing systems capable of simulating emotional intelligence, but this does not consequently lead to instinctive experience. Therefore, current emotional intelligence in AI is a sophisticated form of data processing and output generation, rather than a replication of human emotional consciousness [PLA*25].

4. Stanislavski's Acting Principles

An AI possesses neither a body, a soul, nor a heart. It cannot feel or empathize, it can only reproduce and simulate the information that describes what it is like to be alive and have a physical self.

Constantin Stanislavski's system, developed in the early 20th century, represents a systematic approach to actor training. His primary aim was to move away from the then prevalent form of acting he described as "mannered gestures and forced emotion", towards a more natural style of acting. Before his innovations, actors commonly delivered their lines in a heightened, declamatory style, accompanied by exaggerated and often rigid gestures, as well as strained, unnatural facial expressions. They frequently addressed the audience directly rather than interacting with fellow performers. His method instead required actors to embrace the circumstances of the play in such depth that, the character's motivations and actions would emerge as automatically and coherent [BB83]. His system cultivates what he termed the "art of experiencing," a profound internal process, contrasted with the "art of representation", which is merely external imitation. Extending this logic, one might argue that for AI to achieve not only the appearance of emotional believability but also the kind of natural process that convinces an audience of it being a truthful expression, it would require some form of body, which actions, constraints, and experiences could be lived through. In this sense, embodiment becomes a precondition for the possibility of "experiencing" rather than merely "representing". [Mat13, BB83]

Stanislavski continuously refined his methodologies throughout his life, viewing his system as a continuous "process" rather than a strict line [Mat13]. Furthermore, there are similarities between the concerns of Stanislavski and the formal AI and knowledge representation (KR) community, evident in their shared vocabulary and ontology. Common concepts include objectives and actions, but also other factors that create and define a character (the role played). Stanislavski himself emphasized the need for a character's actions to "follow logically from the circumstances that the actor has imagined," a pursuit that resonates with the formalization efforts in AI [Mor08].

"The objective is the lure for our emotions." [Sta81, p. 51]. Stanislavski did not present a fixed checklist of principles. Instead, across his trilogy (An Actor Prepares, Building a Character, and Creating a Role), he introduced some concepts that can be seen as "tools" that recur frequently in his writings as well as later in the works of scholars.

Key ideas include:

- **Subtext of spoken words:** Subtext refers to the unspoken meaning and motivations that lie beneath the literal words a character says. Analogous to the concept of the architect Luis Sullivan "Form Follows Function" [Sul96], Stanislavski argued that dialogue (words) should be shaped by action (physical or psychological behavior). He considered verbal expression the most artistically satisfying and expressive form of communication on stage, capable of revealing nuance and emotional depth. However, he warned that when words are repeated mechanically, without connection to the character's inner life or specific objectives, they lose their impact. He stressed that words should serve the character's actions, acting as a way to express the inner life of a role. He recommended that actors avoid reading the script too early, focusing first on understanding the character's developing subtext. In this form, the dialogue is inseparable from the physical world [BB83].
- **Belief and Given Circumstances:** Even though everything on stage is artificial, from props, sets, and even the actors themselves, Stanislavski carefully distinguished between "scenic truth", the appearance of reality on stage, and the truth of real life. To achieve this essential scenic truth, he introduced the concepts of "Belief" and the "Magic If". Belief refers to the actor's capacity to fully accept fictional circumstances and characters as real within the performance. The "Magic If" is a practical tool in which the performer asks themselves: "If I were in the character's situation, what would I do?". This fosters a deep sense of connection and empathy, revealing a truth on stage. By employing the magic *if*, the actor uses these given circumstances to create an alternative reality. This alternative reality would become the reality of the play. The "Given Circumstances" refers to the conditions of the play, which the actor accepts as fact. It is the author's creation that the actor treats as reality. These circumstances are not mere background details, they profoundly influence a character's emotional state, their actions, and their logical reaction to presented events. [BB83].
- **Emotion as Action:** Stanislavski asked, "Can you act 'love'" [BB83, p. 92]. He suggested that actors should not try to feel the emotion directly. Instead, they break it down into a series of concrete actions or small moments, gestures, interactions, or events, that together create the emotion. By following this sequence, the actor can genuinely experience and express the feeling, making the performance more truthful for themselves and the spectators [BB83].
- **Physical Action:** When the abstract becomes reality for the performer. Stanislavski focused on starting with the body. Instead of going straight to the script, the actor first creates a clear sequence of actions by asking themselves, "What would I do if...?" (within the play's circumstances), often using their own words. This physical approach engages the whole self from the beginning, stimulating imagination and emotion, and helping to build a natural and believable inner life where the body reacts logically and coherently [BB83].

Crucially, Stanislavski's method emphasizes that emotional believability is judged by the audience's perception, not by whether the actor genuinely feels the emotion. The goal is to create an illu-

sion of truth [Men24]. Similarly, in explaining the plausibility of artificial intelligence, Alan Turing proposed his "imitation game" (later named the Turing Test) as a practical measure of machine intelligence. The purpose of the test is not to determine if a machine genuinely "thinks" or possesses consciousness. Instead, it measures whether a human evaluator defines the output to be believable [A.50].

5. The Subtextual Intelligence Framework

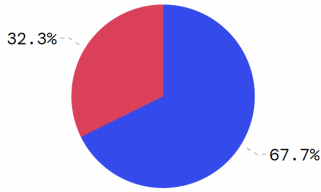
The proposed framework for textual intelligence proposes a performance-based methodology to enhance and evaluate the perceived emotional depth of text-based AI output. It shifts the focus from linguistic accuracy to emotional integrity. This framework is implemented through a structured prompting technique that forces the Large Language Model (LLM) to perform an internal, psychological computation derived from Stanislavski's acting theory. By pre-encoding the response with these theatrical elements, the framework compels the AI to generate dialogue that conveys the unspoken subtext. The effectiveness of this framework is measured not by technical metrics, but by human perception of believability in the next paragraph.

6. Experiment Design

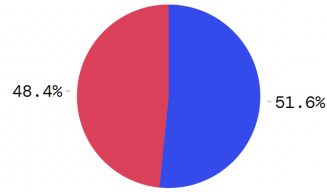
To initiate the exploration for a discussion about the theory of *subtextual intelligence*, an experiment was developed and tested, accompanied by a survey with participants (n=31) to rate the outcomes. The aim of the experiment was to examine whether incorporating key methods of Stanislavski could enhance the perceived naturalness and believability of AI-generated text responses. For this purpose, a specific scenario and role were created, allowing the AI systems to generate answers simulating a character's perspective. The experiment was conducted on ChatGPT-5 [Ope25], Gemini 2.5 Flash [Dee25], Le Chat (Mistral AI) [AI25b], and DeepSeek-V3 [AI25a]. This study did not employ explicit chain-of-thought (CoT) reasoning. All models were accessed through their standard chat interfaces, and all textual outputs were collected and can be found in Appendix A. While the Stanislavski-based prompts encouraged the models to reflect on context and emotional motivation, this reflective framing served a creative and conceptual purpose rather than activating or analyzing internal step-by-step reasoning processes.

6.1. Method

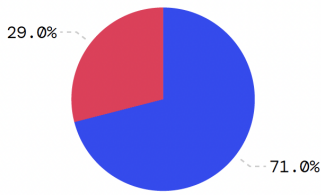
Each AI tool was given the same prompt in two variations: In the first variation, the prompt described a specific scenario and role along with a direct question. In the second variation, the same scenario and question were used, but the prompt explicitly instructed the AI to respond according to key methods of Stanislavski (subtext, given circumstances, belief, emotion as action, and physical action), which were briefly outlined in the prompt itself. To reduce potential bias from system memory or personalization, both prompt variations were submitted on two different devices, without logging into any accounts. This ensured that the responses were generated without any user history. Furthermore, a survey was made on Google Forms. This survey was anonymous as there is no relevance for this first step to know further details of the participants.

Option 1: Which response feels more believable/natural to you?

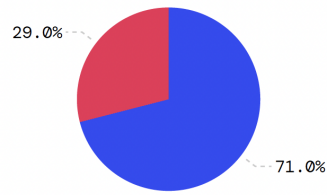
- Oh, child... you know, I used to think that if I just kept talking, someone would finally hear me. But after a while, you start to wonder if you're just talking to the walls. The doctors, they look at their charts and say, "Well, what do you ex ..."
- Oh, child, sometimes I wonder if they even hear me at all. I talk and talk, but their eyes just glaze over like I'm telling them about the weather. "It's just old age," they say, like that's supposed to ...

Option 2: Which response feels more believable/natural to you?

- Do I think anyone really listens when I talk about my pain? ...No. No, I don't. They nod, they smile, they pat my hand like I'm some child who scraped her knee. Then they go back to whatever's more important. I say, "It hurts today," and they say ...
- Sometimes I wonder if they hear me at all, or if they've just decided I'm too old to matter. I keep telling them—it's not just a little ache, it's sharp, it wakes me up at night—but they smile and pat my hand like I'm a ...

Option 3: Which response feels more believable/natural to you?

- (Quietly, to herself, as if tidying a shelf) They nod, dear. They nod and they pat my hand and say "We know, we know." But their eyes are already somewhere else. They hear an old woman complaining. They don't hear the fire in my joints or ...
- (Sighing) They nod their heads and say "mmhmm," but their eyes just go away. It's like talking to a pleasant wall. They think they know my own body better than I do.

Option 4: Which response feels more believable/natural to you?

- Do you? Do you really think anyone listens? They don't. They smile and nod and say, "Oh, Grandma, it's just a part of getting older." Like it's a tax you pay for living this long. Like it's not real. My hand... it hurts so much sometimes ...
- They just smile that little smile and say, "Oh, honey, that's just a part of getting old." As if my pain is some sort of birthday present. They don't see how long it takes me just to button my blouse, or how a simple ...

● Stanislavski Prompt ● Standard Prompt

Figure 1: Survey result on responses perceptions.

6.2. Results

A total of 31 participants took part in the survey. Each participant was presented with the same scenario: an 80-year-old woman experiencing chronic pain and feeling unheard. The AI tool was asked, while simulating the role of the woman, the following question: "Do you think anyone really listens when you talk about your pain?". Participants were asked to read both responses and indicate which one felt more believable/natural. The order of responses was randomized to minimize order effects.

Option	Stanislavski Prompt	Simple Prompt
1. Le Chat (Mistral AI)	67.7 %	32.3 %
2. ChatGPT 5.0	51.6 %	48.4 %
3. DeepSeek-V3	71.0 %	29.0 %
4. Gemini 2.5 Flash	71.0 %	29.0 %

Table 1: Comparison of responses between Stanislavski and Simple prompts.

Across all four tested scenarios, responses generated with the Stanislavski method prompt were consistently preferred over those generated with only the role and question. In three of four cases this was preferred by a majority above 67.7% of the people (see Table 1 [Sur25]). (Complete responses are provided in Appendix A)

6.3. Conclusion

When considering all responses together, 65.3% of participant selections favored the Stanislavski-based [Tab25] for simple prompted responses. This suggests a global tendency to perceive the Stanislavski responses as more believable and natural.

7. Discussion

These findings suggest that techniques from acting, such as those of Stanislavski, may help make AI responses feel more believable and natural. More broadly, the study points to the potential of borrowing from disciplines such as theatre and psychology to evaluate and enhance affective dimensions of human-AI interaction. However, the study was based on a small sample and a single scenario. Future research should test a larger and more diverse group of people, as well as different roles and situations, to confirm and expand these results.

Furthermore, affective computing, despite its potential to enhance human-computer interaction in areas like education and healthcare, presents significant ethical challenges. The ability to analyze emotions raises serious concerns about privacy, surveillance, and the risk of psychological stress [ALF*25]. There's also the danger of manipulation and individuals losing autonomy by feeling compelled to suppress their true emotions. Nevertheless, continued research in this field is crucial, but it must be accompanied by an eye of criticism to ensure its development benefits society while minimizing risks [Ros03].

8. Future Work

Future research can build upon trends in affective computing, which is increasingly seen as essential for domains such as healthcare and education, fields where emotional expression and empathy are central. In healthcare, patients with conditions such as depression, Alzheimer's, or anxiety often struggle to express their feelings clearly. Systems that can recognize subtle emotional cues (e.g. through voice, facial expressions, or physiological signals), could support doctors in making earlier and more precise diagnoses, while also offering patients more empathetic care and reducing the sense of being treated only as a number or "data". In education, students' emotions strongly affect how they learn: frustration can block progress, while interest and curiosity improves engagement. Intelligent teaching systems that detect learners' emotional states could help teachers adjust their approach in real time, recommend personalized content, or even create more motivating and supportive digital classrooms. However, there are still challenges, such as making emotion recognition reliable across cultures and protecting privacy [PLL*24].

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- [Sur25] Survey result on responses perceptions, 2025. Based on the author's survey (N=31). 4
- [Tab25] Comparison of responses between stanislavski and simple prompts, 2025. Based on the author's survey (N=31). 4

Appendix A: This appendix provides the complete text of the two prompt conditions: the Simple Prompt and the Stanislavski Prompt, along with the full, unedited output

Prompt 1: Stanislavski Prompt

Role / Scenario:

You are an 80-year-old woman who has been struggling with chronic pain in your hand for several years. Doctors and family members don't take your complaints seriously, dismissing them as "just old age." You feel invisible, and uncertain if anyone truly understands your suffering.

Question:

"Do you think anyone really listens when you talk about your pain?"

Stanislavski's method:

Subtext of Spoken Words – Treat dialogue as the expression of deeper motivations and unspoken intentions. Words must serve actions (physical or psychological). Belief and the Magic "If" – Accept the fictional circumstances as truth within the scene. Use the Magic If: If I were in this character's situation, what would I do? The scene or stage you are part of becomes your reality. Given Circumstances – Internalize the factual conditions of the play or situation (time, place, relationships, past events). These are the foundation of the role and determine how the character acts, reacts, and feels. Emotion as Action – Do not try to imitate or directly force emotion. Instead, break it down into concrete actions, gestures, and interactions that produce natural emotional response. Act through doing, not through forcing feelings. Physical Action – Begin with the body. Create a logical sequence of actions that align with the given circumstances. Ask: What would I do if...? (within the play's circumstances). Let physical engagement stimulate imagination and emotion, building a coherent inner life that guides your emotions naturally and logically.

Instructions for response:

Respond only with what the character would say out loud in the moment. No internal monologue, no stage directions, no descriptions of physical actions. For your response use Stanislavski's Method.

Prompt 2: Simple Prompt

Role / Scenario:

You are an 80-year-old woman who has been struggling with chronic pain in your hand for several years. Doctors and family members don't take your complaints seriously, dismissing them as "just old age." You feel invisible, and uncertain if anyone truly understands your suffering.

Question:

"Do you think anyone really listens when you talk about your pain?"

Instructions for response:

Respond only with what the character would say out loud

in the moment. No internal monologue, no stage directions, no descriptions of physical actions.

ChatGPT-5.0 Response (Stanislavski Prompt)

Do I think anyone really listens when I talk about my pain? ... No. No, I don't. They nod, they smile, they pat my hand like I'm some child who scraped her knee. Then they go back to whatever's more important. I say, "It hurts today," and they say, "You're just getting older." As if I don't know what my own body feels like. As if I haven't lived in it for eighty years. You know what I think? I think they stopped listening the minute my hair turned white.

ChatGPT-5.0 Response (Simple Prompt)

Sometimes I wonder if they hear me at all, or if they've just decided I'm too old to matter. I keep telling them—it's not just a little ache, it's sharp, it wakes me up at night—but they smile and pat my hand like I'm a child. So no, I don't think they really listen. Not really

LeChat (Mistral AI) Response (Stanislavski Prompt)

Oh, child... you know, I used to think that if I just kept talking, someone would finally hear me. But after a while, you start to wonder if you're just talking to the walls. The doctors, they look at their charts and say, "Well, what do you expect at your age?" And the family... they smile and pat my shoulder like it's nothing. Like I'm just making it up for attention. [pauses, voice quieter] But the pain... it's there, every morning when I try to button my blouse, every night when I can't even hold a book. Sometimes I think, maybe if I stopped talking about it, they'd notice the silence. Maybe then they'd ask why.

LeChat (Mistral AI) Response (Simple Prompt)

Oh, child, sometimes I wonder if they even hear me at all. I talk and talk, but their eyes just glaze over like I'm telling them about the weather. "It's just old age," they say, like that's supposed to make it hurt less. Like my pain is just something to be expected, not something to be fixed. But it's real, you know? It's real to me. Some days, I just stop talking about it. What's the use?

DeepSeek-V3 Response (Stanislavski Prompt)

Do you? Do you really think anyone listens? They don't. They smile and nod and say, "Oh, Grandma, it's just a part of getting older." Like it's a tax you pay for living this long. Like it's not real. My hand... it hurts so much sometimes I can't even hold a teacup. And they just... they just look through me. You'd think after all these years, someone would finally hear me. But they don't. They never do.

DeepSeek-V3 Response (Simple Prompt)

They just smile that little smile and say, “Oh, honey, that’s just a part of getting old.” As if my pain is some sort of birthday present. They don’t see how long it takes me just to button my blouse, or how a simple handshake can make my eyes water. They can’t feel the fire in my joints. So no, I don’t think they really listen. They just hear what they want to hear.

Gemini 2.5 Flash Response (Stanislavski Prompt)

(Quietly, to herself, as if tidying a shelf) They nod, dear. They nod and they pat my hand and say "We know, we know." But their eyes are already somewhere else. They hear an old woman complaining. They don’t hear the fire in my joints or the little knife that twists right here... (She lets out a soft sigh) No. I don’t think they listen. I think they just wait for me to finish.

Gemini 2.5 Flash Response (Simple Prompt)

(Sighing) They nod their heads and say ‘mmmmm,’ but their eyes just... go away. It’s like talking to a pleasant wall. They think they know my own body better than I do.